Divide, Test, Vote

How a team of 6 finds the right problem and builds a blueprint everyone owns

A teamwork method used from day one by The Architects, IEEE ENSI SB

1. What it is

Divide, Test, Vote is a way of organizing a whole team through the first two phases of a challenge, from *"we have no problem yet"* to *"we have a blueprint everyone agrees on"*. It has three simple rules:

- **Divide:** everyone searches alone, in parallel, so the team covers much more ground.
- **Test:** no problem is kept because it sounds good. It is kept only if real people confirm it.
- **Vote:** every decision is taken together, so the final document belongs to all members.

No special software is needed. You need a shared folder, a messaging group and a few video meetings.

2. How we used it

We ran the method in four *stages* (not to be confused with the AOTN phases).

Stage 1: Divide and discover (everyone searches alone)

Our team has 6 members. Each member looked for their own contacts: people who work in the field and could talk to us. We used every format we could get: one-to-one conversations, field visits, phone calls and online meetings. Each member explored a different problem, so several problems were studied at the same time.

Stage 2: Test and filter (drop fast, move on)

We tested each candidate problem with the people we interviewed. When the conversations showed that a problem was not the right one (not real, not painful enough, not solvable by us), we dropped it and moved on to the next one. We compared the problems that were close to each other. The one we kept was the one that attracted both the team and the people we interviewed.

Concrete example. The problem we kept (an industrial-safety problem in Tunisian factories) was confirmed in **4 recorded sessions with 4 people**, held on the same day in **3 formats** (in person on site, phone call, video call) and covering **3 profiles**: a technician who lives the problem every day, two technical managers who decide on it, and an independent industrial-organization expert. Each session produced a log entry with the date, the role, the format, a link to the recording and the key insights.

Stage 3: Write from the evidence

We wrote our problem report from what we actually collected: our voice recordings and phone calls with the people we interviewed. Every statement in the report comes from a real conversation. The writing was collective work.

Stage 4: Blueprint sprint (one idea each, then merge and vote)

- **Kick-off meeting:** we explained every task of the phase and who does what.
- **Individual ideas:** each member prepared their own idea of the solution.
- **Collective meeting:** we put all the ideas on the table and merged them into one solution.
- **Vote:** each idea was kept only if the team accepted it by vote.
- **Final report:** written and then approved by every member before submission.

- **Naming:** the name of the project was chosen at the end, once the solution was clear.

Diagram. We made many attempts at the diagram. Each attempt showed a missing step or an unclear arrow, and the team fixed it before the final version.

3. How your team can use it

Step	What to do	Time
1	Each member lists 3 to 5 contacts and books a conversation (visit, call or online meeting)	Days 1 to 3
2	Hold the interviews. Ask for permission to record. Write a short note the same day	Days 3 to 7
3	Short team meeting to compare problems. Drop the weak ones, keep the best	Day 8
4	Write the problem report from the notes and recordings	Days 8 to 10
5	Kick-off meeting: share the tasks. Everyone prepares one idea	Next phase, day 1
6	Merge meeting, then vote, then write the final report	Days 2 to 5
7	Everyone reads and approves the final version, then you choose the name	Last day

Tools that helped (one per job)

Job	Tool	Why
Diagrams (swimlane, flow, UML)	draw.io app.diagrams.net	Free, needs no account
Interview notes	Google Docs docs.google.com	One shared doc, one note per conversation
Voting	Messenger messenger.com	A simple poll in the team group

Tips

- Choose a clear rule to drop a problem. For example, drop it if two people in a row say it is not a real pain.
- Record the calls (with permission) and quote real sentences in your report. Judges notice evidence.
- Interview different profiles for each problem: a manager, a user, an expert.
- Agree on a voting rule before the meeting (simple majority, or everyone can veto).
- Keep the diagram simple. Show the main path first and the exceptions after.

Mistakes to avoid

- Falling in love with the first problem and interviewing only people who agree with it.
- Merging ideas without a vote, so some members feel unheard.
- Writing the report from memory instead of from the notes and recordings.
- Choosing the name first. A name chosen late describes the solution better.
- Sending the final report before every member has read and approved it.